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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Metra's lobbying runs up big bill

Transit agency spent millions for work on looming budget crisis

By Sarah Freishtat
Chicago Tribune

Metra agreed to pay its lobbyist as much as \$4.65 million in part for work related to a looming transit budget crisis, even as agency leaders brace for a potential shortage of cash caused by the same crisis.

The five-year lobbying contract is in effect as the region's four transit agencies, including Metra, stare down a \$771 million budget gap when federal COVID-19 relief funding runs out next year. Agency heads and advocates have warned that steep service cuts and fare hikes are at stake unless transit gets additional state money.

Yet last year alone, Metra spent more than \$602,000 on lobbyists for help with the budget cliff, along with work on Metra's transition to a less commuter-focused service and advancing other Metra interests at the federal, state and regional level, according to public expense data and a copy of the lobbying contract, which took effect about a year ago.

Such spending on lobbyists is, perhaps, expected, but fails to follow the best interests of taxpayers and riders, said Justin Marlowe, director of the Center for Municipal Finance at the University of Chicago. The spending also makes the case for reform of the way transit is overseen, he said, as two proposals are debated in Springfield that call for either consolidating the region's four transit agencies or boosting coordination among them.

"What you have is an inter-governance structure where it is, in effect, a free-for-all," Marlowe said. "You have money being spent on lobbying to go advance the interests of one agency that may

Turn to Metra, Page 5

CHICAGO PUBLIC SCHOOLS

'Everyone is on edge'

Immigration crackdown leads to numerous reports of ICE agents near district buildings, emails show, as panic and misinformation continue

By Nell Salzman
Chicago Tribune

The Trump administration's crackdown on immigration has led to a string of concerned reports from principals and parents to Chicago Public Schools

officials, according to a review of internal communication from district security personnel.

On Jan. 24, a mistaken CPS report of two U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers at Hamline Elementary School on the South Side spurred

nationwide panic. The two officers were later confirmed to be Secret Service, not ICE — both agencies are part of the U.S. Department of Homeland Security. A security video showed the agents approached the school in a relatively benign manner, despite

high levels of fear that day.

A look at emails from district officials in the weeks since the mistaken ICE report demonstrates that both panic and misinformation around ICE in schools has continued since the Hamline incident. The emails were mostly sent by officials at the CPS' Student Safety Center,

Turn to ICE, Page 6



CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A deal on the doorstep?

Chicago Public Schools CEO Pedro Martinez speaks after meeting with Mayor Brandon Johnson and Chicago Teachers Union President Stacy Davis Gates at City Hall on Wednesday. Johnson called the sit-down in a bid to avert a strike and force the sides to settle a monthslong fight over district finances one day before a vote on a budget amendment. The mayor gave a bullish outlook on the talks, saying there's no need for a work stoppage "when we are so close to landing a deal." **Chicagoland, Page 6**

No mulligan for man who stole famed green jacket

Ex-Augusta National employee sentenced to one year in prison

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

The late golf legend Arnold Palmer used to say the sport he dominated for so many years was "deceptively simple and endlessly complicated."

It's an adage that could also apply to Richard Globensky, a former Augusta National Golf Club employee who stole Palmer's 1958 Masters green jacket from the club's warehouse and sold it to a Florida broker, only to have it turn up in Chicago years later as part of an FBI investigation involving the stakeout of a Lincoln Park mansion, secretly recorded calls and two separate sting operations.



Richard Globensky, a former warehouse employee at Augusta National Golf Club, leaves the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse on Wednesday after being sentenced for stealing Masters merchandise including Arnold Palmer's 1958 green jacket. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

On Wednesday, Globensky was sentenced in Chicago's federal court to a year in prison for his theft of Palmer's jacket, part of a 13-year scheme to steal Masters-related items from the venerable club for auction in the murky market of sports memorabilia, which prosecutors said netted the former warehouse worker more than \$5.4 million.

In handing down the sentence, U.S. District Judge Sharon John-

Turn to Jacket, Page 2

Israeli military seizes part of Gaza corridor

By Wafaa Shurafa,
Julia Frankel
and Samy Magdy
Associated Press

DEIR AL-BALAH, Gaza Strip — Israel said Wednesday that its troops retook part of a corridor that bisects Gaza, and its defense minister warned that attacks would intensify until Hamas frees dozens of hostages and gives up control of the territory.

The military said it had retaken part of the Netzarim Corridor that divides northern Gaza from the south and from where it had withdrawn as part of a ceasefire that began in January. That truce was shattered Tuesday by Israeli airstrikes that killed more than

400 Palestinians, mostly women and children, according to the Gaza Health Ministry.

The advances by Israel, which included sending more troops to southern Gaza, threatened to drag the sides into all-out war again.

The ceasefire had given war-weary Palestinians some respite, allowed a much-needed surge of humanitarian aid into Gaza — and led to the release of dozens of people who had been hostages for more than 15 months.

Within Israel, the resumption of airstrikes has raised concerns about the fate of roughly two

Turn to Gaza, Page 2

Ukraine takes step toward ceasefire deal

President Donald Trump and Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Wednesday that they had a constructive call about moving toward a ceasefire between Kyiv and Moscow, with Zelenskyy agreeing to accept a mutual pause in attacks on energy targets. **Nation & World**

